



Power and IMPENDING GLORY

Only bold strategic thinking and slaying of several sacred cows can lead to the realisation of the Great Indian Dream

— By **KISHORE MAHBUBANI**

The American dream is over. The Indian dream is arriving. Am I exaggerating? Of course, I am. America will remain far more prosperous than India for decades to come (although many now believe that the Indian Gross National Product (GNP) will surpass the American GNP before 2050).

Yet dreams are not about past or present realities. They are about hopes and aspirations for the future. And a big shift in world history has occurred with so few taking note of its implications. Many young Americans no longer believe that they will experience the same improvement in living standards that their parents did. By contrast, many young

Indians believe that they will do much better than their parents.

One of America's greatest strengths was that it was the most optimistic nation on earth. For decades the Americans believed that even the sky was not the limit. This is how they managed to walk on the moon. Gradually this optimism is being sapped away. Don't get me wrong. The Boston Brahmins and the Californian creative class will continue to enjoy the best living standards. They will not suffer. But the American dream was always about how anyone could make it in America. The bottom of the pyramid shared the same dreams.

But the bottom is falling out of the bottom of America. There is real despair in Detroit and Flint, Michigan. By contrast India has been gradually reducing poverty at the bottom. The

percentage of population living on less than a dollar a day has progressively decreased from 42 per cent in 1981 to 24 per cent in 2005.

In short, there is real hope for India. The country can make it and show the way. But to achieve this, India must also be prepared to make bold decisions to shake off some of the millstones around its neck. Amazingly enough, there are some simple solutions readily available for India to grasp.

Take the case of the biggest millstone around India's neck since Independence: Pakistan. There is one simple step India can take: Indian discourse should stop using the word "Pakistan". Instead it should use either "Pakistani Government" or Pakistani People".

Virtually all of the problems that India has suffered have come from the "Pakistani

● The three largest economies in the world in 2050 will be China, India and America in that order, predicts Goldman Sachs.